TASK 1 ESSENTIALS · LESSON 1 CHEAT SHEET

# Select, Describe, Compare

The three skills every Task 1 answer needs, whatever the chart.

## The task: select, describe, compare

*Summarise the information by **selecting** and **reporting** the main features, and make **comparisons** where relevant.*

At least 150 words · about 20 minutes · Task 2 counts twice as much.

**Marked on:** Task Achievement · Coherence and Cohesion · Lexical Resource · Grammatical Range and Accuracy.

## Static or dynamic?

Look for dates in the title, axis or column headings. Any chart type can be either.

| | STATIC: ONE MOMENT | DYNAMIC: CHANGE OVER TIME |
|---|---|---|
| **Pie** | one pie, one year | two pies, two years |
| **Bar** | categories on the axis | years on the axis |
| **Table** | one column of figures | columns for different years |
| **Language** | *the largest share, higher than, twice as many as* | *rose, fell, doubled, overtook, remained stable* |

## Select

**Main features:** the highest and lowest figures, the biggest differences or changes, overall patterns, anything that breaks the pattern.

**Leave out:** small middle figures, reasons, opinions, predictions, descriptions of the chart itself.

## Compare

- X was higher / lower than Y
- X was twice / three times as high as Y
- X had the largest share, followed by Y
- While X rose, Y fell
- X: 14 hours, compared with 3 for Y

A figure on its own is a list. Say how it relates to another.

## Which tense?

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Past years | past simple | *rose, accounted for* |
| Projections, dashed lines | future form | *is expected to reach* |
| No date (processes) | present simple | *water is poured* |
| Past until now (maps) | present perfect | *has been built* |

## Describe accurately

- Describe the data, not the picture: the bar for TV → the time spent watching TV.
- Give the unit with every figure: %, hours, tonnes, US$.
- Axis says *(millions)*: **10 million**, never 10 millions.
- **the number of** + countable · **the amount of** + uncountable
- 5% to 10% is a rise of **5 percentage points**, not 5%.

## Subject–verb agreement

Agree with the **head noun**: *The number of visitors **was** · The percentage of households **has**.*

Percentages and fractions agree with the noun after *of*: *28% of students **were** · 34% of the waste **was**.*

**Singular:** each, every, one of, the chart shows.
**Plural:** both, a number of, the charts show.

## Uncountable nouns

*water, electricity, energy, money, spending, waste, information, traffic, equipment, unemployment*

- No -s: informations, equipments
- Singular verb: *waste **was***
- **amount, less, much** (not number, fewer, many)
- Count with a unit: *litres of water, tonnes of waste*

TASK 1 ESSENTIALS · LESSON 2 CHEAT SHEET

# Structure Your Answer

Paraphrase, overview, two organised body paragraphs and clear signposts.

## Four paragraphs

1. **Introduction:** paraphrase the task. What, who, where, when.
2. **Overview:** *Overall,* + the main features. No figures.
3. **Body 1:** figures and comparisons for one group of features.
4. **Body 2:** figures and comparisons for the other.

**Leave out:** opinions, reasons, a conclusion that repeats the overview.

## Paraphrase the question

| | |
|---|---|
| shows | compares, illustrates, gives a breakdown of |
| the number of | how many |
| the percentage of | the proportion of, the share of |
| from 2010 to 2025 | over a fifteen-year period |
| in three cities | in Paris, Rome and Lisbon |
| gives information about | leave it out: say what is measured |

Change the words and the order. Keep every fact. Never write below.

## The overview

**Static:** the largest and smallest categories and the biggest difference.

**Dynamic:** the overall trend, the biggest change, and whether the ranking changed.

*Overall, rent rose in all three cities, and Paris remained the most expensive throughout, although Lisbon saw the biggest increase.*

## Before you finish

1. Did I select main features, not every figure?
2. Right tense? Every unit? Verbs agree?
3. Does every body paragraph compare?
4. Overview with no figures? Clear signposts?

## Organise the body paragraphs

| PLAN | BODY 1 | BODY 2 |
|---|---|---|
| **By time** | first year | changes, final year |
| **By size** | largest categories | smaller ones |
| **By trend** | those that rose | those that fell |
| **By group** | where A was higher | where B was higher |
| **By chart** | first chart | second chart |

Don't just follow the chart from left to right.

## Signpost your plan

| | |
|---|---|
| **Time** | *In 2015, … By 2025, … Over the decade, …* |
| **Size** | *The largest category was … Turning to the smaller categories, …* |
| **Trend** | *Looking first at the products that grew, … In contrast, …* |
| **Group** | *People under 30 … In contrast, the over-60s …* |
| **Chart** | *According to the pie chart, … Turning to the table, …* |

Avoid Firstly, Secondly and In conclusion.

## Your 20 minutes

1. Read the task and chart: units, dates, static or dynamic? (2 min)
2. Select key features and choose a plan (3 min)
3. Introduction and overview (5 min)
4. Two body paragraphs (8 min)
5. Check tense, units, agreement, word count (2 min)